Problem: Trust in Vehicle Servicing

Sector: Automotive - After-Sales Service & Vehicle Maintenance



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Starting Problem Area

Urban Indian vehicle owners lose confidence in authorized service centres because advisors rarely explain diagnostic findings, cost changes, or delays as they happen. Communication mostly arrives after the fact, if at all, pushing cost-sensitive and time-pressed customers toward unorganized local garages, even though it carries a higher quality and safety risk.

Customers often experience uncertainty and lack of transparency while their vehicle is being serviced. Once a car is handed over at a service centre, the owner mostly loses visibility into what is actually happening to it: what the technician found, why a part is being replaced, what it will cost, and how long it will really take.

The information gap sits between the workshop floor and the customer and it is where most of the frustration in this category comes from.

What customers don't see

- Diagnostic findings
- Reason a part is being replaced
- Cost as it changes
- Realistic time to completion



Empathy Work - Stakeholder Map

Category	Who	Why they matter
Primary	Vehicle owner	Directly affected; pays for and depends on the outcome
Secondary	Service advisor, technician	Directly involved in delivery; their workload and incentives shape the experience
Key influencer	Service centre manager, OEM / dealership policy	Set pricing rules, SLAs, and what advisors are allowed to disclose
Peripheral	Insurance provider, spare-parts vendor	Low direct involvement but can delay or change the job based on part availability, claim approval

Empathy Work - Empathy Map (Vehicle Owner)

Says	Thinks
“Just tell me what's wrong and how much it'll cost” “Why wasn't I told before you started the work?”	Suspects the workshop may be recommending unnecessary work; unsure if the quoted price is fair.
Does	**Feels**
Calls the service centre repeatedly for updates; sometimes switches to a smaller local garage for speed and cost, despite the quality risk.	Anxious about being overcharged; frustrated at being kept waiting without an explanation.

PAINS

Being charged for work that may not have been necessary; finding out about extra costs only after they're already done.

GAINS

A clear cost estimate and real-time updates before decisions are made; confidence that the diagnosis and price are fair.

Validation plan: test the problem before building

Test	What we will learn
12 recent customers	Where uncertainty appeared, which updates were missing, and whether it changed trust or future choice
6 advisors and technicians	When information becomes available, who owns each update, and what would add workload
20 completed job cards	How often cost, scope, or promised delivery time changed after check-in
Complaint-theme review	Whether the same issues recur across centres; record the sample, date range, and source links



Sector-Specific Constraints

Constraint	Effect on a realistic solution
Cycle Time	An app-level pilot can ship in weeks. Retraining advisors takes months to show up in trust scores, since trust is built over multiple visits, not one interaction.
Capital Intensity	The sector runs on physical infrastructure, diagnostic equipment, technicians, spare-parts inventory. New hardware or staff needs real capital before testing at even one location.
Regulatory Constraints	Servicing sits under OEM warranty terms, motor vehicle safety rules, and data protection law where diagnostics or customer data are touched and hence limiting how radically process can change.
Failure Cost	A wrong diagnosis or a skipped safety check is not just a bad review. It can be a real safety issue on the road, unlike a delivery app showing the wrong ETA.

Proposed solution: a live service-status link

At check-in, the owner receives a secure mobile web link, so no app download is required. The link follows the existing service workflow and gives the owner one place to see the diagnosis, estimate, approvals, progress, and expected handover time.

- The advisor posts a plain-language diagnosis with supporting photos when useful
- The owner sees the reason, price, and timing impact before approving extra work
- Every approval and estimate change is time-stamped; safety escalations still follow existing OEM rules



Six-week pilot: what success would look like

Measure	Proposed success threshold
Update coverage	At least 90% of pilot jobs show diagnosis, approval status, and expected completion time
Approval speed	Median customer response within 30 minutes after a complete estimate is shared
Customer clarity	Average post-service score of at least 4 out of 5 for understanding work and cost
Workshop fit	No meaningful increase in technician handling time; advisor effort stays within the agreed limit



Summary

- Run the customer interviews and workflow review first
- If the evidence confirms the gap, test the mobile link at one service centre for six weeks
- Scale only if customer clarity improves without increasing workshop handling time

AI Disclosure

Claude was used to run the AI-assisted synthesis pass over publicly available complaint themes. AI was used for drafting support and thematic clustering, not for generating the underlying judgment calls. We fed a batch of publicly visible service-centre complaint patterns into an AI tool and asked it to cluster the recurring themes, to check our empathy map against a wider sample than the handful of experiences we could personally recall. It converged on the same three themes giving more confidence that the problem is common, not a one-off complaint. Chat-GPT was also used to generate images used in the presentation.